Trends in the consumption of recorded music

Exam code: 9BS0

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Key data

- According to the BPI (British Phonographic Industry), UK spending on recorded music increased by 4.8% to £1.49bn **in 2024**
  - Physical music sales rose by 1.3% to £246.5m
  - Digital download revenue dropped by 6.6% to £24.3 million
  - Streaming revenue totaled £1.02 billion to make up 68.1% of recorded music revenue
- UK recorded music consumption across sales and streams rose 9.7% last year to 200.5 million albums

Physical and digital formats

Dominance of digital consumption

- Since 2014, annual streaming revenue has increased by more than 800% in total to become the **main format for recorded music** in the UK
- In 2024, the UK's music consumption reached a record 201.4 million album equivalents, with streaming accounting for approximately **68% of total recorded music revenue**
  - Paid subscriptions to services such as **Amazon**, **Apple**, **Spotify** and **YouTube** make up the vast majority of streaming revenue
    - These brought in £875.5 million in 2024 and account for more than 86% of the £1.02 billion UK streaming market
  - Digital **download revenue dropped by 6.6%** to £24.3 million, the second year in a row of modest decline

Resilience of physical formats

- Physical formats like vinyl and CDs saw a combined revenue increase of 1.3% in 2024, amounting to £246.5 million
  - Revenue from **sales of vinyl LPs rose** by 2.9% to £145.7 million

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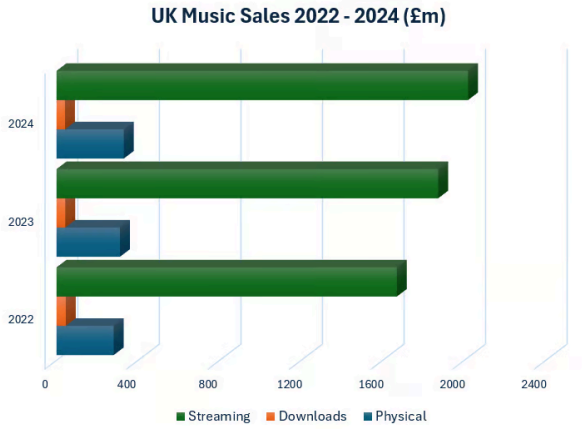
        - In 2014, half of the year's Top 10 sellers were catalogue (older) titles
        - Brand new releases play an increasingly significant role in growth - in 2024 eight of the year-end Top 10 were current releases, including Taylor Swift's *The Tortured Poets Department* and Charli XCX's *Brat*
    - Revenue from **sales of CDs fell by 0.5%** in 2024 to £96.7 million
        - Over the last three years **CD sales have stabilised** to become a £90 million-plus annual market
        - In 2024, purchases totalled 10.5 million units
        - Like vinyl, the CD market is led by the popularity of new releases
        - Examples include new albums by Coldplay and Sabrina Carpenter

Help me understand

Revenue distribution between physical and digital formats over recent years

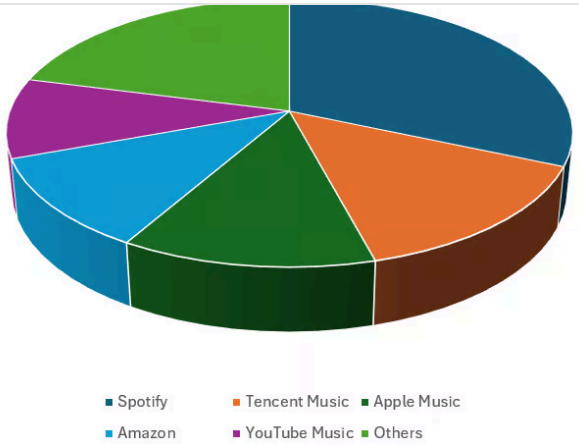


Source: Entertainment and Retail Association, 2024

Dominance of streaming platforms

Market share of streaming services

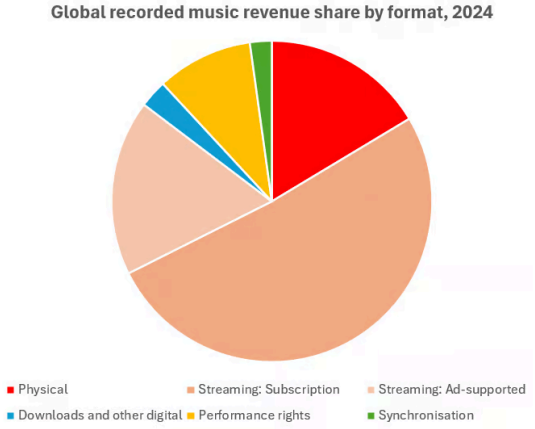
- Streaming platforms like Spotify, Apple Music, and Amazon Music dominate the UK market, with streaming accounting for 68% of total recorded music revenue in 2024



Source: Statista.com, 2024

Subscription growth

- The UK saw a 7.8% rise in streaming subscriptions in 2024, highlighting that there is a growing number of consumers willing to pay for music access
- Streaming has become a significant revenue source for artists



Source: ibfi.org 2024

Growing importance of playlists

- Platforms like Spotify use **advanced algorithms** to curate personalised playlists such as 'Discover Weekly'
  - These playlists increase user engagement and encourage new music discovery
  - They have shifted listeners from active searching to passive discovery, impacting how new music is consumed and popularised

- **Artificial intelligence** is used to analyse user preferences, refining recommendations and influencing listening patterns
    - For artists, reliance on algorithms creates a **challenge for visibility**, as breaking into popular playlists can be competitive and algorithm-dependent

The influence of social media

TikTok's impact on music consumption

- TikTok has emerged as an **important platform for music discovery**, with viral trends leading to mainstream success for some songs and artists
    - In 2024, 10 of the 11 UK Official Chart number ones were tied to major TikTok trends
- The platform has led to the **resurgence of older songs**
    - In 2024, 19 out of the top 50 tracks on UK TikTok posts were more than five years old
- Virality on TikTok often leads to **increased streams** on music platforms, leading to additional revenue and exposure
    - Tik Tok users are 68% more likely to use a paid-for music streaming subscription than the general population
- Musicians are increasingly **using TikTok for promotion** to engage directly with fans and use the platform's algorithm to reach broader audiences

Vinyl revival

- Vinyl sales in the UK have experienced a revival in recent years, with over 6.7 million units sold in 2024, marking the 17th consecutive year of growth
- There are several reasons for this revival
  - Many listeners appreciate the **physicality** of vinyl records, including the larger album artwork and the act of playing a record
  - Vinyl enthusiasts often argue that records provide a **warmer, more authentic sound** compared to digital recordings
  - The **vintage nature of vinyl** records appeals to both older generations reminiscing and younger listeners drawn to retro trends
  - Purchasing vinyl records is seen by fans as a direct **way to support their favourite artists**, especially as streaming royalties are usually small
  - **Record Store Day**, established in 2007, has played a key role in promoting vinyl , encouraging exclusive releases and driving traffic to independent record stores
  - Vinyl releases often include **exclusive content** such as bonus tracks, special artwork and coloured discs, enhancing their appeal
- The return of vinyl records to the **UK's inflation basket** in 2024 reflects their renewed significance in consumer spending habits

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